

Is Death Bad For You? Personal Identity and the Nature of Death

An original lesson plan inspired by **Shelly Kagan's Death (PHIL 176)** (Open Yale Courses). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Open Yale Courses or Shelly Kagan. Explore the original course: <https://oyc.yale.edu/philosophy/phil-176>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Metaphysics, Philosophy of Mind

“If death is simply the end of your existence, can it be bad for you — and what does your answer assume about what you fundamentally are?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Distinguish dualist views of persons (you are, or include, a non-physical soul) from physicalist views (you are essentially your functioning body/brain).
- Explain the “deprivation account” of why death can be bad for the person who dies, despite that person no longer existing to experience any harm.
- Apply competing theories of personal identity (bodily continuity vs. psychological continuity) to a puzzle case involving gradual replacement or teleportation.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard for recording student predictions on the teleporter case
- Printed puzzle-case handout (teleporter scenario and a gradual brain-replacement scenario)
- Two-column handout: “Dualism” vs. “Physicalism” for note-taking

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Teleporter

10 min

Describe a teleporter that scans every atom in your body, destroys the original, and instantly assembles an atom-for-atom duplicate on Mars with all your memories and personality intact. Ask: did you just travel to Mars, or did you die and get replaced by a copy? Take an anonymous vote and record the split — there is usually genuine disagreement, which sets up the rest of the lesson.

Direct Instruction: What Are You, Fundamentally?

15 min

Introduce the dualist view (you are, at least in part, a non-physical soul or mind distinct from your body) against the physicalist view (you are your functioning body and brain, full stop, with no additional non-physical ingredient). Briefly note the main challenge for dualism (how would a non-physical soul interact causally with a physical body?) and for physicalism (can purely physical processes really explain subjective experience?), without resolving the debate.

Small-Group Puzzle Case Analysis

15 min

In small groups, students apply two theories of personal identity — bodily continuity (you persist as long as your physical body/organism does) and psychological continuity (you persist as long as your memories and personality are continuously connected) — to the teleporter case and a second case: a person whose brain cells are replaced one at a time with functionally identical artificial cells until none of the original biological material remains. Each group records what each theory would say about whether the person survives in each case.

Whole-Class Discussion: The Deprivation Account

15 min

Return to the essential question. Introduce the deprivation account: death is bad for the person who dies not because they experience something unpleasant (they don't exist to experience anything), but because it deprives them of the good things they would otherwise have had. Ask: does this successfully explain why death can be bad despite the person no longer existing, or does depriving someone of something require that they exist to be deprived?

Closure

5 min

Ask for a final show of hands on the teleporter case now that theories of personal identity have been discussed. Note any shifts from the opening vote and briefly ask one or two students what changed their mind, if anything.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If the deprivation account is right that death is bad because of the good things it prevents, would an infinitely long life therefore be infinitely good — or could immortality eventually become bad in its own way?
- 2 Does the gradual brain-replacement case feel different from the teleporter case to you? If so, what's actually different about the two scenarios?
- 3 If psychological continuity is what matters for personal identity, does severe memory loss (as in advanced dementia) raise the same philosophical question as death itself?
- 4 Is it coherent to fear your own death, given that (on most views) there will be no “you” left to experience anything bad once you're dead?

Assessment

Students write a short response defending either bodily continuity or psychological continuity as the better theory of personal identity, applying it explicitly to both the teleporter and gradual-replacement cases discussed in class.



Extension Activity

Have students research one real medical or technological case that raises questions about personal identity (e.g., split-brain patients, or proposals for uploading minds to computers) and write a short analysis of what bodily-continuity and psychological-continuity theories would each say about it.

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